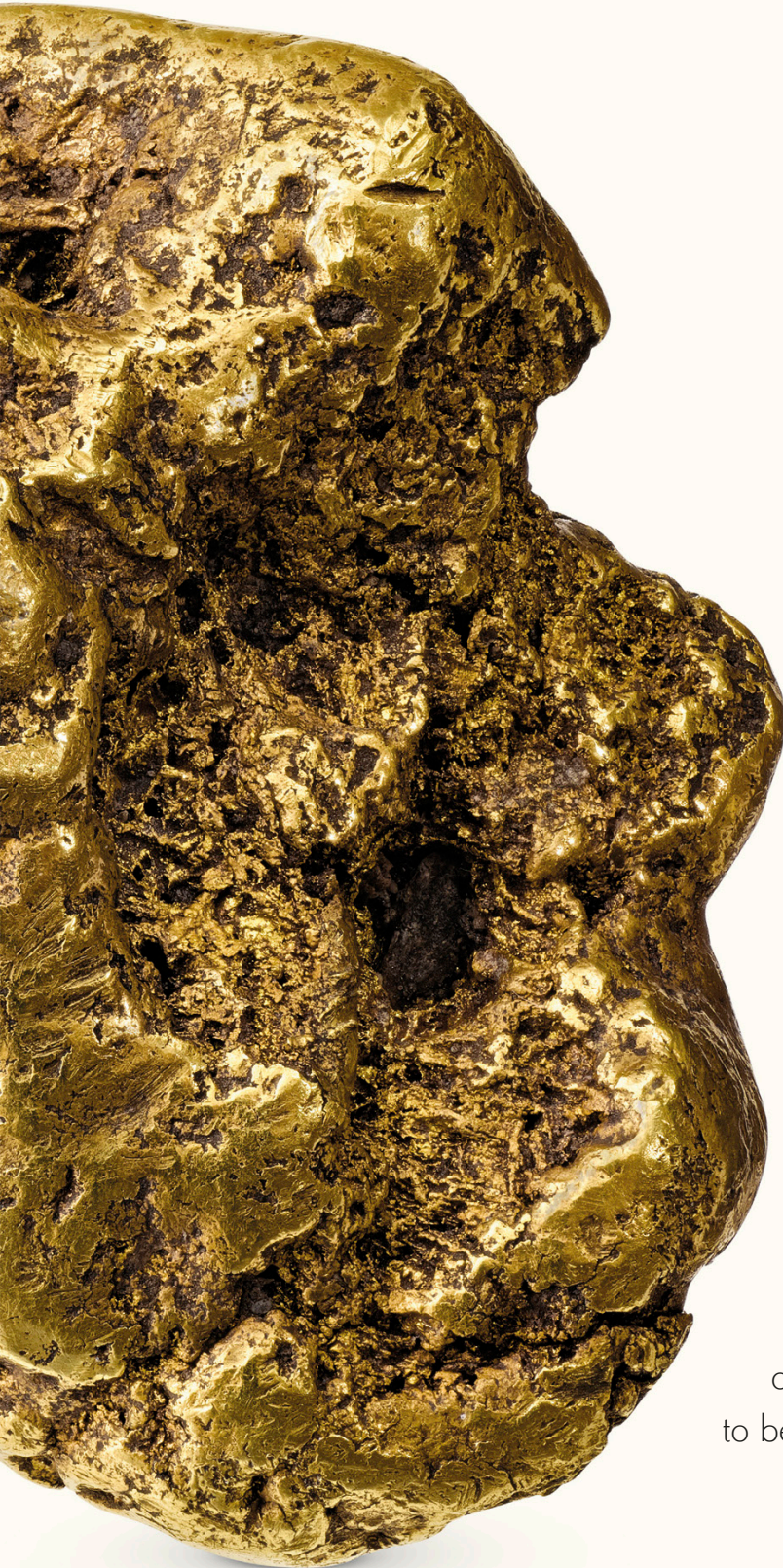


Most of the gold we discover near the Earth's surface came from meteorites that smashed into our planet from outer space.



If you spot a glinting speck at the bottom of a river, it might be gold. Gold is an unusual element because it can be found in solid pieces not locked inside other rocks. It forms as delicate flakes or lumpy nuggets that are often washed into streams.

All through history, people have wanted to own this precious metal. The Inca people of South America thought that gold was the sweat of their sun-god, Inti. In the 1800s, around 300,000 people raced to California, USA, to search for gold on riverbeds. However, only a small number of them found enough to become rich during this “gold rush”.